



All smiles: A jubilant Indumathi Kathiresan poses with the IWL trophy.

Pics: ODISHA FC WOMEN

OFCW scouted players with prior IWL experience, as well as local talent, to contribute to the club's development. Pyari Xaxa, an India international who had won the IWL with Rising Students Club in 2018 and was from Odisha, perfectly fit the bill as the first major signing.

More national team players, such as Shreya Hooda, Karthika Angamuthu, and Anju Tamang, followed, while Odisha State team captain Karishma Oram strengthened the defence.

In its first season itself, OFCW won the Odisha Women's League.

"To be in IWL, we had to win the State League. That was not much of a challenge because we had some of the best national team players," said Chhetri, an AFC 'A' Licence holder of

FIFA, who has been with the team from the beginning, in an interview with *Sportstar*. "But I think it was a good platform for us to build as a team because everyone was new to everything."

Though OFCW strengthened its squad for IWL 2022-23 by signing Ngangom Bala Devi (India's highest goalscorer in women's football) and young prodigy Lynda Kom Serto (the Most Valuable Player at the Under-18 SAFF Championship), the team lost in the quarterfinals to eventual champion Gokulam Kerala, losing 0-3 in penalties. "I think we sorted out many things we didn't do in the first year, and in the second year, as a coach, I knew what kind of players I needed for my team," Chhetri said.

Learning from mistakes

Moving forward, the Juggernauts stuck with their core players — Shreya, Lynda, Pyari, and Karthika —

and signed Indumathi Kathiresan, IWL's best player from the previous season at Gokulam Kerala.

Rather than relying solely on signings, Chhetri focused on improving the learning process at the club. "We passed less information (technical details) and focused more on learning (understanding the game) because if (and when players) go to the national team or other teams, they might have coaches with different philosophies. But if they learn something from me, it's for a lifetime," he said.

With 31 points and as many goals in 12 matches, a rejuvenated OFCW became the champion of India.

"In women's football, it's not just about the quality of the players, but the right mindset and the character in the dressing room," Chhetri said.

"Maybe with talent, you win one or two matches. But if you have the right character, I think you have more chances of winning a championship than with talent and quality alone."

While the club has signed several foreign players over the years, it has primarily preferred Indian players in key positions. This decision has turned out to be a fruitful one.

"I think some foreigners come here not to be part of IWL, but just to be comfortable, play for money, and leave. I need foreigners who want to excel and use this platform to go abroad, so that it sets an example for our youngsters," Chhetri said.

Chhetri's search for leaders may have ended this season with Ghana's prolific striker Jennifer Kankam Yeboah, who joined the club before the AWCL qualifiers. Jennifer scored for fun in the Egyptian Women's League (57 goals in 30 matches) and won the Ghana Women's Footballer of the Year award before moving to India to form a formidable pair with Lynda in front of goal.

"The coach's vision and the conversations we had were key to me joining the club. He outlined how I would fit into the team's plan and how he intended to develop my game," Jennifer told DW in a recent interview. Of OFCW's six goals in the AWCL qualifiers, all — except for two